

THE CLAIM

AI Mode ends the session 92% of the time.

Almost every AI Mode visit closes without a click, close to triple the zero-click rate of a normal Google session.

AI MODE ZERO-CLICK SESSIONS	92–94%
STANDARD GOOGLE, NO AIO	about 34%
STANDARD GOOGLE, WITH AIO	about 43%

Semrush, AI Mode clickstream study, July 2025.

One in six sources in AI Mode is Google itself.

The sidebar pulls most of its sources from the existing top ten. If you are not there, you are not in the answer.

GOOGLE.COM SHARE OF AI MODE CITATIONS	17.42%
SAME FIGURE, JUNE 2025	5.7%
TYPICAL SIDEBAR DOMAINS	about 7
OVERLAP WITH THE TOP TEN	51%

SE Ranking, March 2026; Semrush, AI search tools study, June 2025.

92-94%

of Google AI Mode sessions end
without a single outbound click.

AI MODE ZERO-CLICK RATE	92-94%
STANDARD GOOGLE, NO AIO	about 34%
GOOGLE.COM SHARE OF AI MODE CITATIONS	17.42%
SIDEBAR OVERLAP WITH THE TOP TEN	51%

Semrush clickstream, July 2025; SE Ranking, March 2026.

The question is split before it is searched.

STEP 01

The query is decomposed into sub-questions

STEP 02

Google searches, then reads the top results

STEP 03

The sidebar names about seven domains

CITATIONS PULLED FROM THE TOP TEN 51%

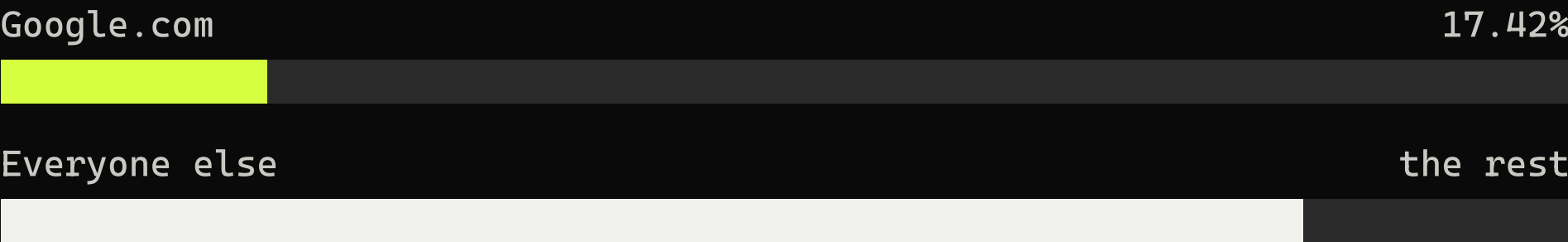
DOMAINS SHOWN IN THE SIDEBAR about 7

Semrush, 5,000 keyword and 150,000 citation study of AI search tools, June 2025.

AI Mode cites Google more than anyone.

17.42%

Google.com share of sources
cited inside AI Mode, up from
5.7% in June 2025.



MOST-CITED FORUM	Reddit
DOMAIN OVERLAP, AI OVERVIEWS	about 86%

SE Ranking, March 2026; Semrush, AI search tools study, June 2025.

Get into the seven, or stop **counting clicks**.

01 Aim to be inside the top ten, not below it

Half of all AI Mode citations come from pages already ranked in the top ten. Rankings still gate the citations.

02 Answer the sub-questions, not just the headline question

The query is split before it is searched. Pages that answer the smaller parts get pulled in.

03 Stop measuring AI Mode with session data

At 92% zero-click, sessions cannot show you this. Track citations and impressions instead.

Sources: Semrush, July 2025 and June 2025; SE Ranking, March 2026.

THE TAKEAWAY

Run your main query in AI Mode. Count the **sources**.

If your name is not in the list of seven, that is the whole problem, in one screenshot.

STEP ONE	screenshot the sidebar sources
STEP TWO	check which of the seven you could outrank
FOLLOW	if you are doing this weekly

Sources: Semrush and SE Ranking, 2025 to 2026.